



United in spirit: Participants competed in the 21.1 km marathon (above), the 1.9 km swim (facing page), and the 90 km bike ride — a combined total of 113 km, or 70.3 miles. PICS: SPECIAL ARRANGMENT

First steps

Each year, Ironman sees a host of debutants, and among those making his bow was Sriram Venkitaraman (**below**), an IAS officer from Kochi. Having started with cycling and running, he decided to take up the triathlon at the suggestion of his wife. "We come to Goa every year, and because it was happening here she was very keen that I do it," he said.

After training with coaches for cycling and swimming (he started swimming just three months before Ironman), he finished in just over six hours. "One of the greatest feelings I've had in recent years, mind-blowing," he said, describing the feeling of finishing the race. "To call yourself an Ironman is the greatest thing." Has the triathlon bug bitten him now? "Absolutely, I'm going to come back next year and better my time," he said.

Consistent crowd support throughout the race also stood out. Unperturbed by an early start, large crowds made their presence felt as the sun rose to help participants begin their swim leg. That support remained throughout, with spectators lining the biking and running routes as well.

The right vibe

Dr Jack Sequeira Road towards Dona Paula was a particularly impressive sight. In what seemed like the blink of an eye, it turned from an

empty street into a thronging mass of people urging competitors through the second transition, and ultimately cheering them home as they completed their courses.

"Goan fans are the best," Sriram said of the crowds. "Especially during the run, when your legs are gone and you somehow have to cross the finish line, fans were the ones that kept us motivated. They were a big reason that I finished."

"The more people there are, the more fun it is," said Hardik. "I had a really great experience in Copenhagen, where it felt like the entire city had lined up back to back on the entire course, and it's similar here also in a lot of places."

An extra note of praise was reserved for the volunteers who dotted the course to assist participants. "It was super — the voluntary services, everything was very good everywhere. On the run route, on swim, on bike, things were beautifully organised," Shilpa said.

Sometime later, the roads would have cleared, and the bike racks on Miramar Beach would have disappeared. What will be left is a memory of a day when, armed with the support of that raucous local crowd, it became more than merely a race course. Under the sweltering sun, it became a canvas upon which hopes, dreams, and ambitions came to fruition across 70.3 miles.

